

Sakshi (Sakṣī)

Product Title: Sakshi

Sakshi means “witness” in Nepali, someone who sees a thing directly and can speak to it.

Product Description

Sakshi is a free mobile app for people visiting heritage sites, starting with the sacred garden of Lumbini and the monument squares of the Kathmandu Valley. It guides a visitor to stand in the right spot, at the right angle, and helps them take a photograph that lines up exactly with one taken before, whether that was last month, last year, or a century ago. That one act, done by an ordinary visitor with their own phone, produces something a normal tourist photo never does: a picture a conservation officer can genuinely compare against the last one, and trust.

Nepal’s heritage sites are visited by millions of people every year, but they are formally inspected by experts only once every few years. In between, a crack widens, moss spreads across a stone plinth, a centuries old water spout quietly stops flowing, and almost none of it gets written down anywhere. A 2019 survey of the Kathmandu Valley’s traditional stone water spouts found that of 573 once in use, 94 had already run dry for good. Sakshi does not try to replace the experts. It fills the years between their visits with a steady, dated, trustworthy record, collected by the people who are already there.

What It Does

- Tells the story of where you are standing. Point the app at a monument and it explains what it is and why it matters, in Nepali or English, drawn from real historical sources, never guessed.
- Helps you take a photo that counts. At a marked viewpoint, the app lines your phone up with where a past photograph was taken, and only lets you capture once the position and angle genuinely match. A snapshot becomes a measurement.
- Lets you report what you see. Noticed a new crack, a stain, water that used to flow and no longer does? File it in under a minute, photo attached.
- Puts it in front of someone who can act. Every report reaches a dashboard the site’s caretaker can see and respond to, acknowledged, in progress, or resolved. Nothing disappears into a folder nobody opens.
- Answers questions honestly. Ask the built in guide about a site’s history, or a question of Buddhist teaching, and it answers only from real, cited sources. If it cannot find the answer in a real source, it says so instead of making one up.

What Makes It Stand Out

- “Not a photograph. A measurement.” The app will not let you take the picture until you are standing in exactly the right place, facing exactly the right way, so two photos taken months apart can be honestly compared, not just eyeballed.

- “An AI that is allowed to say I don’t know.” Most chat assistants would rather invent an answer than admit they do not have one. Ours checks its own answer against real sources before showing it, and refuses to answer at all if it cannot find one.
- “The tourist becomes the guardian.” A visitor comes for the history and leaves having quietly helped protect it, with no extra trip, no special training, and no cost to them.
- It never dresses up a guess as a fact. Any reconstructed or imagined image is clearly labelled as such and never allowed to pass as a real historical photograph.
- It works with no signal. Deep inside a monument precinct with no network, the app still works, since records are saved on the phone first and sent along whenever a connection appears.
- It is free for visitors, always. No ads, no coupons, no points to collect or trade. Sakshi will never take money from a business operating inside a site it is helping to watch over, that is a published promise, not a claim.

Where It Stands Today

Sakshi won first place at the LumbiniX 2026 national hackathon. It now covers 15 heritage sites across two regions, Lumbini and the Kathmandu Valley, fully bilingual in Nepali and English, built independently by a team of four students.

Where It Is Going

We start with Lumbini and the Kathmandu Valley. From there, the same idea extends to any of Nepal’s hundreds of protected monuments, and eventually to any heritage site anywhere that is visited far more often than it is ever formally inspected. The app stays free for visitors permanently. The plan is to sustain it by working directly with the institutions responsible for these places, not by selling attention back to tourists.

Team Everest: Aaditya Sapkota, Binayak Gautam, Nabin Poudel, Siddanta Sodari. Chitwan, Nepal.